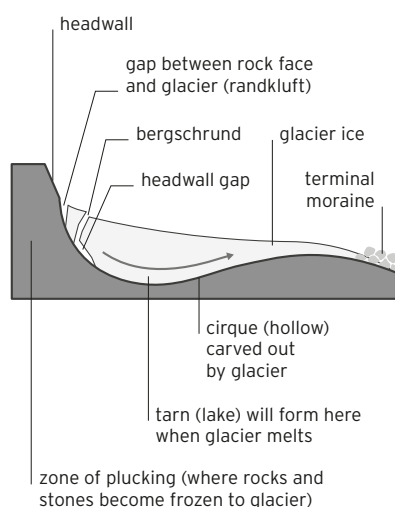


CINDER CONE A steep-sided volcano made up of ash, cinders, or clinker (rough, irregular lava fragments). Also called a scoria cone. See also *volcano* (panel).

CIRQUE ▼ A steep-sided hollow at the head of a valley or on a mountainside carved out by a glacier. Many glaciers originate in mountain cirques, from which they flow to lower ground. See also *glacier*.



CIRQUE GLACIER A glacier that originates in, and is mostly restricted to, a cirque. If a cirque glacier advances far enough, it may become a valley glacier. See also *cirque*, *glacier*, *valley glacier*.

CLAST A fragment of gravel, sand, or other sediment incorporated into another, newer rock. For example, sandstone is made up of many clasts of sand. See also *grain*.

CLAY An earthy material with mineral particles smaller than about 0.00008 in. (0.002 mm) in diameter. Clay is porous, but water flows through it only slowly.

CLOUDFOREST A damp forest that is often shrouded in cloud. Cloudforest is generally found high in mountains.

COLD DESERT A desert that becomes very cold for at least part of the year, due either to high elevation or high latitude. Examples of cold deserts are Antarctica and the Gobi Desert.

CONDENSATION The conversion of a substance from a vapor to a liquid. Clouds form when water vapor condenses to form tiny droplets of water.

CONFLUENCE The place where two streams, rivers, or glaciers join.

CONIFEROUS Cone-bearing. Firs and pines are examples of coniferous trees.

CONSERVATIVE BOUNDARY A margin along which two tectonic plates slide past each other in opposite directions or at different speeds. See also *boundary* (panel).

CONSTRUCTIVE BOUNDARY See *divergent boundary*.

CONTACT METAMORPHISM The process by which very hot intrusive igneous rocks alter the country rocks around them. See also *country rock*, *igneous intrusion* (panel), *metamorphic rock*.

CONTINENTAL CRUST The layer of mainly sedimentary and metamorphic rocks that forms the continents and the relatively shallow oceans close to their shores. See also *continental shelf*, *crust*, *oceanic crust*.

CONTINENTAL DIVIDE A continent's drainage divide. Water on either side of the divide drains into different oceans or seas. See also *watershed*.

CONTINENTAL MARGIN The zone of the ocean floor that separates thin oceanic crust from thick continental crust. The continental shelf, continental slope, and

continental rise together make up the continental margin. See also *continental shelf*, *continental slope*.

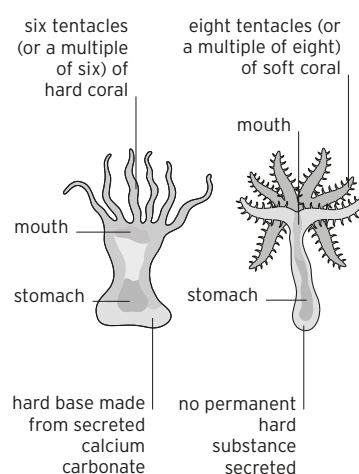
CONTINENTAL RISE The lowest part of the continental slope, adjacent to the abyssal plain. See also *abyssal plain*.

CONTINENTAL SHELF The submerged, gently sloping portion of continental crust between the coast and the continental slope. See also *crust*.

CONTINENTAL SLOPE The sloping ocean floor between the continental rise and the continental shelf. See also *continental rise*, *continental shelf*.

CONVECTION The movement of gases, liquids, and molten rocks in response to differences in temperature. One example is when air is warmed as it passes over hot ground and rises high in the atmosphere.

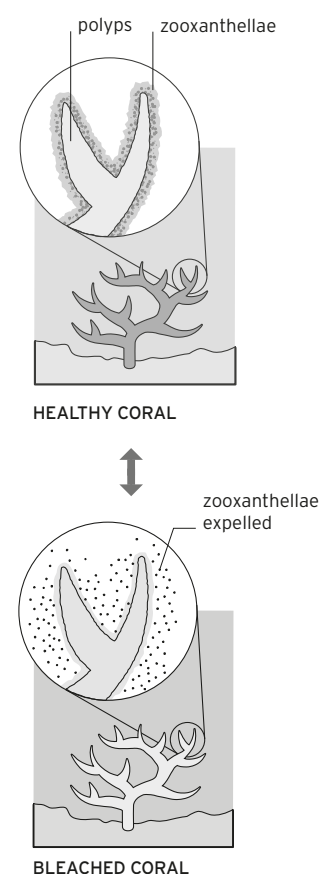
CONVERGENT BOUNDARY The line along which two or more tectonic plates move toward each other and collide. The result is either a subduction zone or a continental collision. See also *boundary* (panel), *subduction*, *tectonic plate*.



CORAL ▲ An ocean-dwelling invertebrate. Corals often live in huge colonies and can secrete calcium carbonate skeletons to

support themselves. The accumulation of these corals eventually produces a coral reef. See also *coral reef*.

CORAL BLEACHING ▼ The process whereby corals expel the color-giving algae (zooxanthellae) from their tissues and consequently turn white. One of the main causes is an increase in the temperature of seawater. Bleached corals are not necessarily dead, but bleaching can lead to death.



CORAL REEF ▼ A structure built up over many years from the skeletons of corals. Examples include fringing reefs, barrier reefs, and atolls.

